



CENTER FOR STRATEGIC LEADERSHIP
U.S. ARMY WAR COLLEGE

INTERNATIONAL STRATEGIC CRISIS

ISCNE

NEGOTIATION EXERCISE



Korea Scenario



UNITED STATES ARMY
WAR COLLEGE

The International Strategic Crisis Negotiation Exercise

Exercise Description and Guidance

Introduction

The International Strategic Crisis Negotiation Exercise (ISCNE) is designed to use experiential learning to educate participants in the process of crisis negotiations at the international/strategic level.

Participants, as part of a delegation team, will be challenged in their leadership style, negotiating techniques, and communications abilities to reach their team's desired end-state. Each delegation engages with counterparts, within the framework of the Six-Party Talks conference, to resolve a long-standing, and potentially volatile, crisis. An actual resolution to the presented issues is not an expectation, nor is it a reality. Delegations will have to contend with friendly, and adversarial, teams that each have their own desired end-state goals.

The crisis in question is over the Korean Peninsula. Countries with interests in this region, and involved in the negotiations, are China, North Korea, South Korea, Japan, Russia, and the United States.

The key documents provided are the Korea Six-Party Talks Scenario, Privileged Instructions, and Korea Six-Party Talks References. As the name implies the Privileged Instructions are protected communications from each government to their negotiation delegations regarding the impending round of talks and need to be handled as such.

This type of exercise works best when conducted within the confines of a strict schedule. This allows the parties involved time to negotiate issues, pause to evaluate and adjust their negotiation strategies, and schedule and respond to negotiation requests. The strict structure may induce some level of frustration, but this is not unrealistic. Within the context of this exercise all parties have accepted a United Nations negotiation model which establishes the structure and employs a control group concept.

Preparation for the Exercise

It is highly suggested that each delegation find time to meet and prepare prior to the exercise, if possible.

Each delegation must have both a Head of Delegation (HOD) and a Team Communicator.

As the title implies, the HOD is the delegation lead. This person is responsible for providing direction to the delegation and is responsible to their superiors, in the form of their Foreign Minister/Secretary (FM/S) as role-played by the Senior Controller. Which negotiation sessions the HOD elects to attend (or not to attend), is symbolic of their significance within diplomatic circles.

The Team Communicator is a full team member that has the additional duty of being the delegation's point of contact with the exercise control team. They are responsible for requesting and processing ad hoc negotiation invitations, team-to-team communication and diplomatic communiques as detailed below. This duty is critical for exercise execution.

Exercise Operations

As part of the Six-Party Talks' efforts, all parties agreed to the imposition of certain predetermined sessions and control mechanisms to ensure the proper conduct of the negotiations. For that purpose, a Control Group (CG) has been established, as the technical and administrative branch, to help manage the conduct of this peace conference and ensure implementation of the agreed mechanisms. These mechanisms are:

- **Ad Hoc Negotiation Scheduling:** Ad Hoc negotiation sessions are scheduled via an electronic system accessed by your delegation's communicator (not by direct delegation-to-delegation communication). Ad Hoc sessions must adhere to the negotiation periods set out in the exercise

schedule. Sessions may be bilateral or multilateral and may be requested for 15- or 30-minute increments. Invited parties may *accept*, *decline*, or *ignore* the invitation. Once all invitees have responded, the system notifies all parties on whether the session will be held and if so, where. **Ad Hoc Negotiation Sessions only happen if all parties agree to attend.** A delegation may request and schedule as many negotiation sessions as it can support within the allotted time. **If you accept an invitation, you must attend the session.**

- **Diplomatic Communiqués:** These are messages to your nation's leadership to either provide reports or to request guidance. The Senior Controller will provide his cell phone number to the Head of Delegation and Team Communicator so that they can text him directly. If a delegation would like to meet with him, he will come to your team room during Team Meeting periods.
- **Team-to-Team Communication:** Delegations are allowed to communicate with each other as they determine appropriate but ***may not conduct negotiations outside of formally scheduled negotiation sessions.***
- **Exercise Schedule:** Adherence to the exercise schedule will be strictly enforced. Team Meeting periods are an extremely important element, they are a time for internal team communication, evaluation of positions of the other delegations, consultation with their FM/S, scheduling negotiation sessions, and establishing talking points for the next round of negotiations. Negotiations between delegations can only take place during the scheduled negotiation periods.

Conduct of the Exercise

The exercise begins following the exercise overview brief. At the opening plenary session, chaired by the Chinese Foreign Minister, role-playing portion of the exercise begins. Participants should remain in role throughout. Negotiation sessions and team meetings are confidential but conversations in common or public areas are subject to intelligence collection.

For the opening plenary each delegation should be prepared to present a 2-3 minute opening statement. Upon conclusion of the plenary participants will move to their team rooms and prepare for the commencement of negotiations. The first negotiation is pre-scheduled bilateral sessions. Thereafter, all sessions will be Ad Hoc, conducted as described above. The first day concludes with an internal team evaluation of the day's events.

The second day begins with a Team Meeting period followed by the resumption of negotiations. At the end of the day teams will reassemble for a closing plenary chaired by the Chinese Foreign Minister. ***During the closing plenary each delegation will brief their current positions, assess the progress made, and offer options for any proposed way forward.*** Specific instructions on the closing plenary will be sent to each delegation during the last Ad Hoc negotiation session. At the conclusion of the plenary participants will come out of role and the Army War College will facilitate an after-action review.

INTERNATIONAL STRATEGIC CRISIS NEGOTIATION EXERCISE

Korea Six-Party Talks Scenario



This exercise introduces and reinforces negotiation techniques and strategic decision-making in a scenario-driven gaming environment.

The scenario utilized for this exercise depicts the crisis on the Korean Peninsula. The scenario's purpose is to provide a near real world situation and set the stage for delegation team negotiations which are the primary actions of the exercise.

The scenario is completely hypothetical and has been designed solely as an aid to achieve participant educational learning objectives. All materials in this exercise are notional for educational purposes only. There is no attempt to be predictive or reach a real-world solution.

Read and understand the materials in this priority and order:

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|--------------|---|
| Required: | Your Delegation's Privileged Instructions (separate document) |
| | Chairman's Framework (pp. 1-2) |
| | Publicly Held Positions (pp. 2-3) |
| | Recent Significant Events (p. 3) |
| | Korean Peninsula Background (pp. 14-30) |
| Recommended: | Korean Peninsula Background (pp. 4-13) |
| | Korea Six-Party Talks Scenario References (references link) |

Overview

This exercise and the scenario, for which it was developed, are designed to engage participants in multilateral negotiations concerning the current situation in North Korea. To accomplish this, a replication of the previous Six-Party Talks, which were held between 2003 and 2008, was determined to be the best and most realistic platform through which the issues are presented and negotiated. Designers made every attempt to both replicate the Six-Party Talks' format and to present the current issues within that construct; however, certain liberties have been taken to create a better exercise. For example, the "Chairman's Framework" (below) was not employed as part of the original Six-Party Talks but is included here to help frame the specific issues for discussion between the delegations.

Chairman's Framework for the Resumption of Six-Party Talks

Parameters agreed to by all parties attendant to the final session of preparatory talks concluded on 1 April 2025 on the resumption of the Six-Party Talk process

It is the sense of the representatives of the governments of China, Japan, North Korea, Russia, South Korea and the United States that a resumption of the Six-Party process is warranted given the need to find a path toward resolving the ongoing crisis on the Korean peninsula. Key issues for discussion are summarized below.

- **Security Guarantees:** This issue is framed around guarantees and commensurate actions that would ensure the nonuse of force by all sides to ensure peace and stability. Whether those discussions on this issue will include talks toward the negotiation and conclusion of a peace treaty to end the Korean War or might also encompass inter-Korean talks regarding reunification were not determined through these preparatory meetings.
- **Peaceful Use of Nuclear Energy:** The issue centers on whether the DPRK, if it returns to and becomes a member in good standing under the Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT), should be allowed to possess a civilian nuclear program. There is general agreement, with only the DPRK delegation abstaining from any discussion on this matter, that the disposition of the DPRK's current nuclear weapon and ballistic missile programs and the North's acceptance of the return of IAEA monitoring and inspection of any nuclear-related facilities that remain must precede any discussion of this issue.
- **Diplomatic Relations:** In the past the DPRK has offered that it would give up its nuclear weapons program in return for the normalization of diplomatic relations across the board. Representatives of the DPRK and ROK governments look to a definitive end to the Korean War as a first step in the resolution of the normalization process. The DPRK insists that this step is required before the issue of denuclearization can be addressed. The United States and Japan hold that denuclearization must be resolved and completed before a formal end to the Korean War and the normalization of relations can be addressed. The other parties have expressed no specific positions regarding this topic.
- **Sanction Relief and Trade Normalization:** The DPRK remains adamant that sanctions are meant to create humanitarian crises. Pyongyang insists that any movement on these issues must also be tied to an agreement on immediate humanitarian assistance. The United States and Japan maintain that sanctions relief and trade normalization can only be addressed once the nuclear and ballistic missile issues are resolved and attendant agreements successfully implemented. South

Korea, China and Russia advocate for incremental sanctions relief to reward progressive steps taken by the DPRK.

- **Disarmament:** Japan and the United States hold that the DPRK must completely dismantle its nuclear program, as verified by the members of these talks and the IAEA. China and Russia agree on a milder, step-by-step solution involving the provision of certain rewards (e.g., aid) in return for each step of nuclear disarmament. North Korea remains adamant that its nuclear and ballistic missile programs are for self-defense/deterrence purposes only, and possession of such a capability is its right under international law until all threats are removed and all relations normalized.
 - **Light Water Nuclear Reactors:** Given the need for additional sources of electricity for North Korea, the possibility for the installation of Light Water Reactors (LWRs) in the DPRK for the provision of electric power, as codified in the 1994 Agreed Framework, will be reconsidered in exchange for the closure of the North's nuclear power program.
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Publicly Held Positions

Democratic People's Republic of Korea:

The nation of North Korea has the right, as it is the right of any nation, to build and hold weapons of whatever type for its own defense and to deter any nation that might threaten their nation. Pyongyang only seeks to be recognized as a nation among nations, an equal member of the world community. Its people have the right to live unencumbered of all threats to their own peace and security and depend on their leaders to ensure their continued wellbeing. The DPRK will only be a nuclear free nation when the rest of the world is nuclear free.

Republic of Korea:

Seoul seeks to normalize North-South relationships through a Peace Treaty to formally end the Korean War, and the eventual reunification of the Korean peninsula – a united Korea living in peace and prosperity under one flag. But this requires Pyongyang to realize that there can be no peace and no prosperity if it holds and threatens other nations with nuclear weapons. The North Koreans must understand that no nation wishes to see their nation collapse, or their leaders deposed. Until Pyongyang comes to that realization, and in order ensure the defense of South Korea and the overall region, Seoul will support and retain a unified position with the United States and Japan in demanding the end of the North's nuclear and ballistic missile programs.

People's Republic of China:

Negotiations are the only way to solve the existing problems on the Korean Peninsula; therefore, talks must and will continue until a resolution is reached. It is the responsibility of all nations to these talks to engage in honest negotiations and to honor and abide by all agreements reached. North Korea does have the right to live as an independent nation and be accorded all attendant rights, to include the right to a civilian, nonmilitary, nuclear power capability. China will oppose any violation of North Korean territory or airspace outside of a formal declaration of the use force as outlined by the UN Charter. The PRC supports the immediate provision of humanitarian aid to North Korea, but only through a finding of need as determined by officials of the World Food Program.

Japan:

The nation of Japan will continue its close coordination with the United States and South Korea to assert maximum pressure on North Korea to give up its nuclear weapon and ballistic missile programs. Only in this way can the DPRK expect to be provided recognition as member in good standing of the world community of nations. With its continued threatened use of ballistic missiles, in combination with nuclear weapons, the DPRK can only be seen as a pariah nation. Only once Pyongyang reforms its aggressive conduct and acknowledges and apologizes for the many wrongs committed against our citizens, will Tokyo consider establishing normal diplomatic and economic relations with the DPRK.

Russian Federation:

Moscow believes that the Korean peninsula should be denuclearized in terms of nuclear weapons. The ability for North Korea to retain a civilian nuclear capacity, strictly for power generation, is acknowledged and should be granted under strict IAEA inspection regimes. This requires the DPRK to return to and become a member in good standing of the Nuclear Nonproliferation Treaty (NPT). Russia stands ready to supply immediate economic aid to the affected areas of North Korea, and once an agreement is reached to resolve the current crisis, to open economic and infrastructure efforts in order to help revive the DPRK's economic sector.

United States of America:

The DPRK must agree to a package that includes the disablement and disassembly of its nuclear and ballistic missile programs and an end to all nuclear proliferation activities. Only when such an agreement is implemented, with the disablement and disassembly supervised and certified by responsible international authorities, and the DPRK returns to the NPT as a member in good standing, will the United States look toward formally ending the Korean War and recognize the DPRK as deserving of normalized relations. At that point we will look toward providing whatever assistance is needed to ensure the care and wellbeing of the North Korean people. We stand with South Korea, as we see the reunification of the Korean peninsula as a single democratic nation under one flag as the ultimate solution.

Recent Events

(*Notional)

2026

January 25*: President Xi Jinping announces the resumption of the Six-Party Talks. A statement by the Chinese Ministry of Foreign Affairs that delegates will begin work on the framework to guide this round of talks.

April 1*: The "Chairman's Framework for the Resumption of the Six-Party Talks" are agreed upon by all delegations.

May 2*: Delegations arrive in Beijing from North Korea, South Korea, Japan, Russia, and the United States. The Six-Party Talks are set to begin tomorrow.

Korean Peninsula Background

Historic background 1392-2002

The geography of the Korean peninsula permits the dynamic relationships that have historically dominated this part of Asia. A relatively small border, with continental Asia, and strong seas on three others has shaped the people and their heritage.

In 1392 CE, General Yi Seong-gye (이성계) established the Joseon Dynasty (조선왕조) which overthrew the Goryeo Dynasty (고려왕조). This ushered in the longest continuous dynasty on the Korean peninsula. During the early reign of King Sejong the Great (세종대왕), 1418-1450, numerous reforms were made and the Korean alphabet, Hangul, was created. Relative peace over the land lasted until 1592 when Japanese Warlord Toyotomi Hideyoshi invaded the Korean peninsula. The Imjin War lasted approximately seven years, until 1598. Hideyoshi occupied the southern peninsula and later captured Pyongyang (평양시) and Hanseong (한성) [present-day Seoul (서울시)]. Eventually, Korea's navy gained control over Japanese supply routes. Ming China intervened in 1593 pushing the Japanese back and eventually their retreat to Japan.



Sejong the Great (세종대왕)

Following these events, the Korean Kingdom became increasingly isolationist. The war also took its toll on the Ming Dynasty as it fell into ruins and the new Qing (大清) Dynasty emerged. In 1627, and subsequently in 1637, the Manchus invaded Korea. Both instances forced the kingdom to become a tribute to the Qing Dynasty. This subservient position to China began a period of external peace that lasted over two centuries. During this time of closing off to the outside world earned the nickname "Hermit Kingdom."

As the 19th century began Korea slowly open to western nations, especially those of France and the United States. This opening to the west had significant consequences. With growing numbers of converts to Catholicism, due to French influence, the regime massacred French missionaries and converts in 1866. France retaliated by invading, and occupying, Ganghwa Island (강화도). Eventually the French withdrew. Later that year the crew of the US merchant ship SS General Sherman became stranded in the Taedong River (대동강). Prior to running aground, the SS General Sherman's Captain had been warned that they were not allowed to trade in Korea. They had been mistaken as a French Naval warship and thought were there to avenge the deaths of French missionaries.



SS General Sherman ablaze

Once grounded, some of the merchantmen dispatched ashore to forage for food. During which they took a Korean official hostage. Civilian onlookers surrounded and began to attack the General Sherman. The General Sherman opened fire with her cannons which prompted the Koreans to dispatch troops and improvised warships to retaliate. Eventually the General Sherman was set ablaze, and the merchantmen jumped overboard to avoid the flames. Reaching the shore, the merchantmen were subsequently killed by the civilians. Korea never notified the US regarding the incident.

Five years later the US sent an expedition to ascertain the fate of the General Sherman. The Koreans ambushed the expedition and after repelling the attack ended up capturing and occupying several Korean forts.

In 1876, the Joseon Dynasty relaxed its self-imposed isolation and entered a trade treaty with Japan. In 1882, a treaty with the United States followed. Korea began opening to more regional influences. This caused competition between their old patron, China, and the Imperial Japanese. Additionally, Czarist Russia was searching for warm-water ports in their Eastern Governorates. Internally, Korea was struggling between reformers and the traditionally conservative court.

July 1882 riots broke out in Seoul as a revolt by Korean army soldiers were against King Gojong's (고종) reforms and modernization. Their fear was that Japanese officers would be incorporated into the new army structure. Rioters killed government officials and set their houses on fire. A Japanese contingent barely escaped on the HMS Flying Fish. Finally, the regent Father of the king, Heungseon Daewongun (흥선대원군), took power and re-established order. The aftermath led to the Japanese sending back their ambassador accompanied with four naval vessels and a battalion of soldiers.

The Japanese-backed reformers failed in the three-day Gapsin Coup of 1884. The pro-Chinese conservatives crushed the coup attempt with support of a Chinese garrison stationed in Korea. Chinese influence led to the informal domination in Korea's politics through 1894.



Emperor Meiji
(明治天皇)

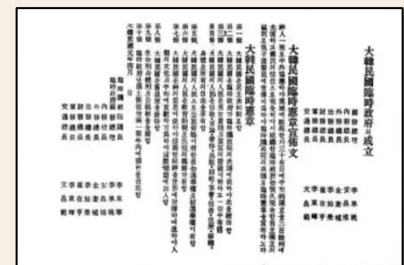
After centuries of its own self-imposed isolation, Japan began to move from a traditional feudal society to a modern society under the vision of Emperor Meiji. This was in great part due to the forced openings initiated by western nations, the first initiated by the United States, followed by Great Britain, and France. Japan's own industrial revolution began around 1870, and the increased demand for resources to fuel its accelerating expansion drove the empire to increase trade with its neighbors. As Japan's military strength grew, so did their subjugation of those same nations.

While Japan rose as an international power, the Qing Empire in China began to wane. The definitive shift in East Asian power came with the Japanese victory over the Qing in the Sino-Japanese War of 1894-1895, which was fought for influence over Korea. The defeat ended the Qing Dynasty, and in part led to China's "Century of Humiliation." Over this same period, Korea

continued to open to the world, establishing their first embassies in several nations, including Japan. Economic relations with Japan flourished, by 1890, Japan was Korea's largest trading partner, and Japanese made up the largest immigrant community in Korea.

Japan finally broke through as a recognized international power with their victory over Russia in the Russo-Japanese War of 1904 and 1905. As a result of its victory, Korea became a protectorate of Japan, and was annexed to Japan under the 1910 Japan-Korea Annexation Treaty. Over the years, a harsh Japanese regime sought to suppress Korean culture and traditions and extracted labor and massive resources from the peninsula to fuel their economic expansion.

Following the end of WWI, those in active resistance against Japanese control of Korea established a provisional government in exile in Shanghai, China. From that time forward, the "Provisional Government of the Republic of Korea" was considered the *de jure* government of the Korean people. The preamble of the 1948 Korean constitution enshrined this. Resistance to Japanese rule in the name of the provisional government continued throughout WWII. Resistance also found expression through religion, specifically through the growth of Christianity throughout the country.



1919 Provisional charter of the
Republic of Korea

During WWII, the Japanese escalated their efforts to destroy Koreans as a separate people, outlawing anything that had to do with their history or culture, and making worship of Japanese installed Shinto shrines mandatory. Tens of thousands of Koreans were forced to serve in the Japanese military, while around 200,000 girls and women from both China and Korea, were forced to serve as "comfort women," essentially sex slaves for Japanese soldiers, an issue that continues to plague Japanese relations with China and South Korea to this day.

Trusteeship Then Division

In November 1943 the Republic of China, Great Britain, and the United States met at the Cairo Conference, where among other things, they decided that Korea would become an independent nation. At the Yalta conference, in February 1945, it was decided Korea would enter a four-power trusteeship. The Republic of China, the Soviet Union, Great Britain, and the United States would administer this trusteeship.

After the Soviet Union entered the war against Japan, the Soviet navy made an amphibious landing on the eastern shores of the northern part of Korea on 14 August 1945. The next day the Japanese government accepted the surrender demands of the United States government.



Allied Powers meeting in Yalta

The Allied Powers met in Moscow over a period of ten days in December 1945 to discuss and set in place post-WWII treaties and obligations. Regarding the now split occupation of Korea, the Soviet Union and United States decided to form a joint commission between the two military commands to:

"Work out measures...for helping and assisting (trusteeship) the political, economic and social progress of the Korean people, the development of democratic self-government and the establishment of the national independence of Korea."

This would be part of an overarching five-year, four-power trusteeship that would, in consultation with Korean democratic parties and organizations, ensure the creation of governments on each side of the 38th parallel as overseen by the American and Soviet military commands in the region.



Kim Il-sung (김일성)

The objective of trusteeship was to build a consensus government that would govern a united Korea after Soviet and American forces had withdrawn. However, the Soviet Union and United States backed Korean political parties and leaders whom, much like their backer nations, had diametrically opposed political and nationalist philosophies. The Americans supported Syngman Rhee (이승만) of the Independence Promotion Central Committee, while the Soviets backed Kim Il-sung (김일성) of the Korean Communist Party. Subsequently, as the chasm between the two parties became irreconcilable, the joint commission became deadlocked on even the possibility of forming a national government. In September 1947, the United States brought the question to the UN General Assembly.

Meanwhile, the Republic of Korea (대한민국) formally came into existence on 10 May 1948, followed by the Democratic People's Republic of Korea (조선민주주의인민공화국) on 12 October, with both declaring they were the one true government of all Korea and all Koreans. The United States won its argument when the UN General Assembly, despite strong Soviet objections,

passed Resolution 195 (12 December 1948), recognizing the ROK as the sole legal government of Korea.

The Soviet Union withdrew forces in late 1948, followed by the United States in mid-1949. As Soviet and American forces exited the Korean peninsula, the military balance of power decidedly shifted toward the communists in the north. The United States left behind a relatively weak South Korean military led by Syngman Rhee, a seventy-year-old politician and academic educated in the United States. By contrast, the Soviets ensured that the army and air forces of the DPRK were well equipped. Stalin himself ensured that the northern forces, called the Korean People's Army (KPA), maintained modern medium tanks and artillery. The Soviets empowered a strident communist and experienced guerilla fighter, Kim Il-sung, as the leader of the DPRK. He filled the army with officers and soldiers he had fought alongside against the Japanese in China. Their air force was equipped with older propeller-driven fighter aircraft, but their pilots were trained on more modern aircraft in China and Russia.



Syngman Rhee
(이승만)

The Korean War

Once in power it was always Kim's aim to unify the Korean peninsula under a single communist government. Almost as soon as American forces completed their withdrawal from South Korea, Kim petitioned Moscow for permission to invade the south. Stalin rebuffed Kim's request at first. With Mao Zedong's (毛泽东) victory in the Chinese communist revolution in October 1949, he promised support for DPRK actions. Only then did Stalin approve the invasion.

Although Moscow provided planners and trainers, Stalin was adamant that under no circumstances would the Soviet Union commit forces to the invasion, in part because he did not want to be involved in direct conflict with the United States, whom he was certain, would intervene in support of the South Koreans.



South Korean refugees evacuating Seoul

After a year of bloody clashes along the 38th parallel, the war officially began on 25 June 1950. Conflict initiated when Northern forces entered South Korea along the west coast near the Ongjin region, in response to a supposed attack by ROK forces. Following an amphibious landing along the southwest coast, Kim's army quickly overwhelmed ROK forces, captured Seoul, and drove the remaining forces south. By mid-August, KPA forces had reduced the South Korean Army (ROKA) to approximately 22,000 men and pushed them further into the extreme southeast corner of the peninsula into what would be called the "Pusan (부산) Perimeter."

The Truman administration's decision to intervene was not primarily based on securing South Korea as an independent, democratic nation, but rather over concerns of having a communist Korea, heavily influenced by China and the Soviet Union, just across the straits from Japan. With concerns that this action might be a ruse by Moscow to force the Washington to expend significant assets defending Korea as a prelude to a war in Europe. After a communique from Moscow indicated the USSR would not intervene in Korea, the United States and South Korea took the issue to the UN Security Council. On 27 June 1950.

The UN Security Council passed UN Security Council Resolution 83, which condemned the invasion and recommended member states provide military assistance. At the time, the Soviet Union was boycotting the UN over its recognition of the Republic of China, rather than the People's Republic of China as a UN member. The People's Republic of China had no representation within the UN, as it was not recognized.

The United States Army entered the conflict on 5 July. Task Force Smith, a unit comprised of just 540 soldiers from the 24th Infantry Division flew in from Japan. They, and the rest of the 24th ID that followed, suffered heavy losses. Even as the US Eighth Army, and additional UN forces deployed onto the peninsula, the KPA continued to push further and further south.

The KPA was primarily a ground force with little to no air or naval assets, which made their supply lines very vulnerable. To relieve forces trapped in the south, General Douglas MacArthur, sought and gained approval for an amphibious landing far to the north at Inchon, just west of Seoul, in an attempt get behind and isolate the KPA.

The US X Corps led the mid-September landings. Its units rapidly advanced east and defeated KPA forces in and around Seoul. Almost simultaneously, the newly arrived 1st Cavalry Division spearheaded the "Pusan Perimeter Breakout" and rapidly advanced north to link up with X Corps. Meanwhile, with American air attacks decimating KPA tanks and artillery assets. What remained of Kim's forces (25,000 to 30,000 men) were unable to affect an orderly retreat, leaving the north vulnerable to counterattack.



GEN Douglas MacArthur observing the naval shelling of Inchon

On 27 September, MacArthur received National Security Council Memorandum 81/1, stipulating those offensive operations north of the 38th Parallel were only authorized if there was no threat of invasion by the USSR or China. The South Korean government was restored on 29 September. The next day, US Secretary of State George Marshall penned an "eyes-only" message to MacArthur stating, "We want you to feel unhampered...to proceed north of the 38th parallel." That same day, Chinese Prime Minister Zhou Enlai (周恩来) warned the United States that it was willing to intervene in Korea if US forces crossed the 38th Parallel, however President Truman dismissed the threat.

On 1 October, ROKA forces drove the KPA across the 38th parallel. Under a new UN authorization, on 7 October ROK, United States and UN forces, crossed the parallel and advanced rapidly, capturing Pyongyang on the 19th. As UN forces advanced into North Korea, US Army airborne units parachuted in along the Chinese border to secure major crossing points into China to prevent the North's leaders from escaping into China. MacArthur wanted to extend the offensive into Chinese territory to

eliminate North Korean supply depots, but President Truman warned against it, although, again, he did not personally believe Chinese threats to intervene militarily.



People's Volunteer Army troops

In consultation with Moscow and citing "American aggression in the guise of the UN," Mao decided to intervene by moving 200,000 Chinese troops into North Korea as the People's Volunteer Army (PVA). Employing guerrilla tactics, the Chinese troops moved only at night and remained camouflaged in place during the day. Given the robust commitment of Chinese forces into Korea, the Soviet Union

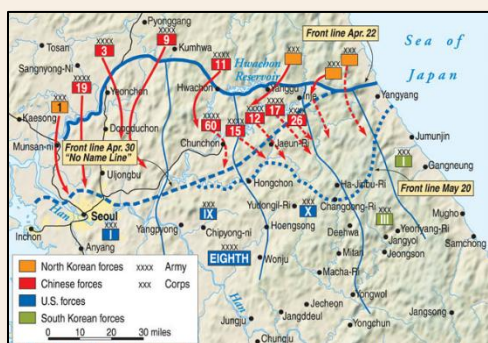
decided to provide air force assets to support PVA's ground operations. PVA forces crossed the Yalu River (압록강) into North Korea on 19 October, the same day that UN forces captured Pyongyang, and began their offensive against ROKA and UN forces on the 25th.

The PVA inflicted heavy casualties on ROKA forces as they moved north and surrounded the 8th US Cavalry Regiment; however, the Chinese forces withdrew into the central mountains instead of continuing their offensive. This withdrawal confused the UN command, leaving them to doubt whether the Chinese had intervened. Believing that Chinese were not involved, on 24 November, the 8th US Army resumed its advance in the northwest as X Corps paralleled them in the east. The next day, the PVA's 13th Army Group attacked in the west and overran the ROKA II Corps and inflicted heavy casualties on the US 2nd Infantry Division, forcing US 8th Army forces to retreat south. In the east, on 27 November, the PVA's 9th Corps attacked the US 7th Infantry Division and 1st Marine Division, with both barely escaping encirclement. With the US 8th Army executing a long retreat in the west, and X Corps evacuating by sea in the east, the Truman administration was forced to declare a national emergency.

Continuing their drive south, PVA forces recaptured Seoul on 4 January 1951. UN forces continued to retreat south until they were able to stabilize their positions, in great part because the PVA outran their logistics lines, and they possessed limited assets to move equipment and supplies forward to sustain their offensive beyond Seoul.

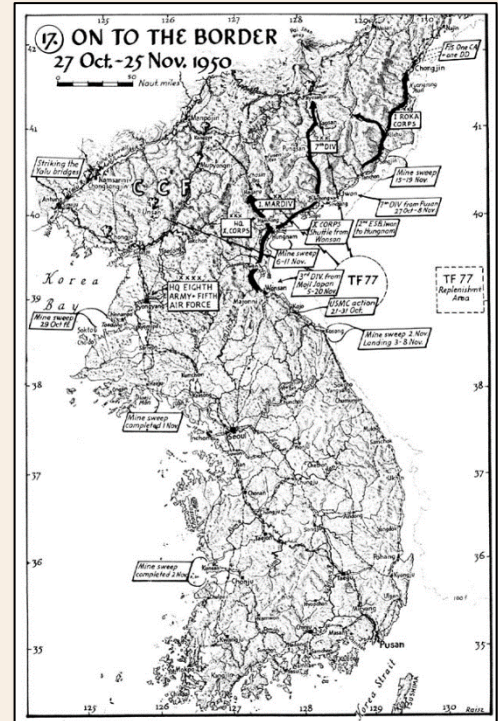
Over the course of the next six months, as UN forces strengthened, the UN command conducted a series of counterattacks that depleted the PVA and KPA forces. In late March, the UN command launched two infiltration operations designed to trap PVA and KPA forces in the vicinity of Seoul. Additionally, on Easter Sunday, US airborne forces executed Operation TOMAHAWK, parachuting in behind Chinese forces to block their movement north.

In response, the PVA initiated their "Chinese Spring Offensive," deploying three field armies consisting of some 700,000 troops. The new PVA force began their offenses in late April, first in the east against US I Corps in the battles of Imjin River (설마리 전투) and Kapyong (가평전투); then in the



Spring Offensive 1951

west against the ROKA and US X Corps at Soyang River. After some initial gains both attacks were repulsed. In April President Truman fired General MacArthur, promoting General Matthew Ridgway to Supreme Allied Commander, Korea. By the end of May, a resurgent US 8th Army attacked in the east, finally advancing north of the 38th parallel to "Kansas Line," where they halted. The "Kansas Line" halt and subsequent stand-down of renewed offensive actions, combined with the PVA and KPA's inability to mount effective offensive actions of their own, began the stalemate that lasted until the armistice of 1953.



UN Forces Actions Oct-Nov 1950

On 10 July 1951, armistice talks began at Kaesong (개성시), later moving to Panmunjom (판문점). Over the next two years as negotiators talked, the war continued as each side jockeyed for more

favorable positions. There were several fiercely fought battles, with the Battle of Heartbreak Ridge (단장의 능선 전투) and the Battle of Pork Chop Hill (石岬洞北山戰鬥) among the more legendary. After two years of difficult talks, an Armistice Agreement was signed on 27 July 1953, officially ending the fighting but not the war.

The agreement created a 5 mile-wide Demilitarized Zone (DMZ) and setup the Neutral Nations Supervisory Commission (NNSC), composed of members from the Swiss and Swedish Armed Forces, which remains stationed near the DMZ. It took another year before the sides could agree on a method to exchange their dead. While the Armistice called upon North and South Korea, China, and the United States to continue negotiations to conclude a peace treaty, those talks were never held.

Meanwhile, relations with China that had begun to sour during the war with Mao denouncing Kim for fighting an “idiotic war” and being an incompetent military commander. In turn, Kim condemned China's Cultural Revolution as “unbelievable idiocy.”

Consolidation and Provocation

As both sides recovered from the catastrophic effects of the war, Kim Il-sung gradually consolidated his power, conducting show trials and executing many of his opponents. He was soon ruling as a complete autocrat, and over time succeeded in creating a cult of personality, modelled on Stalin, where he would be seen as the sole face of North Korea in every way possible. He would eventually displace Marxism-Leninism with his *Juche* (주체사상), self-reliance ideology.



Kim Il-sung Juche poster

North Korea worked to shore up relations with fellow Communist nations by signing two Mutual Aid and Cooperation Friendship Treaties. Kim signed an agreement with the Soviet Union and followed up a few days later by signing a similar agreement with the People's Republic of China.

Because there was no actual peace treaty, North Koreans still consider themselves to be at war, and even though Kim Il-sung had declared victory, stating, “Despite their best efforts, the imperialist invaders were defeated with great loss in men and material.” In 1966, Kim declared it a national duty to liberate South Korea. Over the years, there have been many incidents of aggression by North Korea along the DMZ, at sea, and outside the region. In January 1968, the North Korean Navy captured the USS Pueblo, a US Navy spy ship. Also in 1968, North Korean commandos tried unsuccessfully to assassinate South Korean President Park Chung-hee (박정희). In April 1969, a North Korean fighter jet shot down a US Navy EC-121 reconnaissance aircraft, killing all 31 onboard.

By 1970, with leadership changes in Moscow and Beijing (北京市), relations between the former allies began to return to normal. In 1972, the North and South held their first formal talks since the Armistice, although nothing of significance came from them.

The 1970s saw a significant uptick in actions initiated by the DPRK. Beginning in 1974, North Korean forces began digging incursion tunnels under the DMZ in the area north of Seoul. In August 1976, North Korean soldiers entered the Joint Security Area (JSA) at Panmunjom and killed two US soldiers who were cutting down a poplar tree, known as the “Axe Murder Incident.”

In 1975, as the North Vietnamese Army entered Saigon following the US exodus signaling the end of the Vietnam War, Kim Il-sung visited China to request support for a renewed invasion of South

Korea. Though publicly supportive of Kim, Mao privately refused, in great part because Beijing had already decided to improve its relations with the United States.

Recovery, Political Turmoil, and Growth

In South Korea, the return of Syngman Rhee to office saw the continuance of autocratic rule during what was known as the First Republic period. As the United States turned its focus away from Asia, Rhee rigged elections, arrested opposition members, forced through legislation to eliminate presidential term limits, and ensured the adoption of constitutional amendments that made the presidency a directly elected position.

As the government became increasingly repressive, protests by students and citizens began to break out across the country. In response Rhee imposed martial law, but by late April 1960, the deaths of innocent students and the government's decision to suppress protests by shooting into crowds caused resistance to increase across the country, which forced Rhee to resign and flee into exile.



Protesters of the April Revolution

The Second Republic was a short-lived attempt to establish a democratic form of government. It held power for less than a year before being overthrown on 16 May 1961, in a military coup led by Major General Park Chung-hee (박정희), ostensibly undertaken to prevent the state from collapsing into communism. Park's military regime declared anti-communism and reunification as the nation's overarching policies. Relations with western democratic nations, especially the United States, would be improved, and a return to civilian rule would be achieved in two years. Although he vowed that military leaders would not become involved in politics, Park ran for president and won by a slim margin.



Park Chung-hee (박정희)

Park's election marked the establishment of the Third Republic. In those years, relations with Japan were finally normalized. Though the new treaty brought loans and compensation for damage during colonial rule, it did not come with an official apology which sparked protests and continued to be an issue of contention between both nations, especially in terms of the "comfort women."

With Park's priority on growth and modernization through "Development First, Unification Later," the ROK began to sustain real economic growth and infrastructure development. In the first ten years after the war, the South had fallen well behind the DPRK in terms of economic development. However, over the next 30 years, the South would vastly outpace the North in business and infrastructure development, especially in technology, manufacturing, and trade.

Contrast and Divergence

Despite significantly increased industrialization and educational opportunities, the ROK, with its more temperate climate and flatter terrain, remained an abundant agrarian society more than able to meet the needs of its people. The DPRK however, was unable to adequately feed its own population due to the predominantly mountainous terrain, cold climate, urban population, and endemic waste, corruption, and inefficiencies. Nonetheless, Kim refused to seek external assistance, declaring that his country would achieve total self-sufficiency in food production.

Despite Kim's optimistic declaration, in the years after the war, the North funneled most of its resources and human capital toward industrial development and enlarging its military establishment. While this shift to industrial development created immediate economic advancements, the DPRK remained an isolated nation with few export partners, and its economic expansion soon reached its limits of sustainability. To finance its expansion, the DPRK had borrowed extensively against the value of its vast mineral wealth; however, the oil crisis of 1973 significantly reduced the international value of the North's native mineral exports.

The North, with extensive debt that it could not pay off, could not provide the level of social welfare to which its society had become accustomed. To make matters worse was that the North remained on a war footing, investing mass sums in retaining and arming its vast military complex. These factors caused North Korea to default on its debt in 1974, and by 1985 Pyongyang had halted almost all foreign debt repayments.

As North Korea foundered, Pyongyang could only watch as the South stabilized, found its economic footing, and began its enormous economic expansion. As a hallmark of its nation's progress, Seoul was awarded the opportunity to host the Games of the XXIV Olympiad in 1988. With the Olympic Games less than a year away, an incident occurred that was intended to sow fear and reduce attendance at the games.

On 29 November 1987, two North Korean agents placed a bomb in an overhead compartment onboard Korean Airlines Flight 858. The plane was bound for Seoul from Bagdad, with a stopover in Bangkok. The bombers placed and activated the bomb before they deplaned in Bangkok. The bomb exploded over the Andaman Sea, killing all 115 passengers and crew. One of the two assailants was captured, survived cyanide poisoning, and confessed to the bombing. She indicated that it had been ordered by Kim Jong-il (김정일), the son of Kim Il-sung. The United States declared it a terrorist attack and eventually listed the DPRK as a state sponsor of terrorism, remaining there until 2008.



Wreckage of Korean Air flight 858

The Sixth Republic came into being in February 1988 with the first democratic election in 16 years. The government of Roh Tae-woo (노태우) immediately worked to remove all vestiges of authoritarian rule, establishing the modern and truly democratic system of government that remains the bedrock of the South Korean nation.

To revitalize the DPRK's worsening economic situation, in the mid-1980s, Kim endeavored to improve relations with the Soviet Union and Warsaw Pact. By 1988, DPRK investments and bilateral trade with the Soviet states increased to \$2.8 billion. However, the 1991 collapse of the Soviet Union effectively severed this needed source of assistance, leaving China as his only ally.

Kim and his leaders considered the collapse of Eastern Bloc communism as confirmation of the correctness of the *Juche* philosophy. Around the same time, China, now under the leadership of Deng Xiaoping (邓小平), decided to gradually balance its relations with both Koreas without losing influence with Pyongyang. Given their close geographic location, and the similar state of their growing economies, it was inevitable that China and South Korea would come to see themselves as natural trading partners.

To appease Pyongyang, Beijing's initial openings to South Korea were restricted to indirect trade through Hong Kong and other places, but by 1988, that trade had increased to \$3.8 billion a year.

China and South Korea established formal diplomatic relations in August of 1992. Conversely, China's trade with North Korea stagnated at around \$500 million.

China took great pains to mollify Kim Il-sung to keep from alienating North Korea. Kim regarded it as another indication that China was willing to sell out the North. This also took place at a time when Pyongyang was looking to warm its own relations, especially with Japan and the United States. It was during this time that the DPRK's quest for nuclear technology and weapons became an urgent priority, eventually becoming a concern not only for the region, but for the rest of the world.

In July 1994 Kim Il-sung passed away. Following the death of Kim his designated successor, son Kim Jong-il, was declared Supreme Leader in October 1997. Kim Jong-il began quickly to consolidate power and eliminate potential rivals.

In October 1994, the DPRK and the United States signed the Korean Energy Development Organization (KEDO) which is referred to as the Agreed Framework. The intent of KEDO was to initially freeze and eventually dismantle the North's nuclear weapons program. The framework provided for two nuclear reactors to the North with assurances that it would not be invaded again.



Kim Jong-il (김정일)

South Korean President Kim Dae-jung (김대중) saw an opportunity to improve North-South relations and implemented the "Sunshine Policy" (대북화해협력정책) in 1998. The Sunshine Policy allowed South Korean companies to start projects in the North. Kim announced plans to import and develop their software industry.

As warming of relations between the North and South continued both Kim Jong-il and Kim Dae-jung met during a summit held in Pyongyang, North Korea in June 2000. Through their joint statement at the conclusion of the summit both Koreas agreed to a system of reconciliation and cooperation. Reunion of dispersed family members and the connection of the Gyeongui (경의선) and Donghae (동해선) rail lines were just two outcomes of the meeting.

During US President George Bush's State of the Union address, in January 2002, he characterizes North Korea as part of the "axis of evil." Later in 2002, Japan and North Korea met multiple times to address the kidnapping of Japanese citizens. Japanese Prime Minister Junichiro Koizumi (小泉 純一郎) visited Pyongyang and met with Kim Jong-il. The summit produced a formal apology by Kim, and the return of known victims, and the Japanese government made its first apology to the North for "turmoil and suffering" endured by their citizens from 1910 until 1945.

In October 2002, the DPRK admitted to having produced nuclear weapons since the 1994 Agreed Framework with the United States. Kim cited the presence of American nuclear weapons in South Korea. Secretary of State Colin Powell states that the US intends to move more deliberately and with patience in order "not to create a crisis in the region." To make matters more tense in December the North sends a letter to the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) stating that the status of its nuclear facilities is a matter between the US and North Korea. They subsequently cut all seals and disrupt IAEA surveillance equipment on its nuclear facilities.

A Nuclearized North Korea and the Six-Party Talks

In January 2003 North Korea declared its withdrawal from the nuclear Nonproliferation Treaty (NPT). United States reactions, and consequently DPRK reactions had virtually pushed Seoul to the

sidelines. South Korea felt sacrificed for US interests and concerns. This brought about a strain on ROK-US relations which would continue through the Bush administration.

March 2003, Beijing started to fill the void by arm-twisting Pyongyang to join in three-party talks with the United States. In June, the lead North Korean negotiator, Ri Kun (리곤), bluntly stated that the North would build a “nuclear deterrent” unless it saw a significant change in US policy.

China initiated the first Six-Party Talks on 27 August 2003 in Beijing between the People’s Republic of China, Japan, Democratic People’s Republic of Korea, Republic of Korea, Russian Federation, and the United States. This would become the centerpiece of negotiations over the next six years, led by persistent Chinese delegations, but for all the time and effort spent, these talks never really made any headway. This was due in great part to the stubbornness born by both the American and North Korean sides. Openly personal animus was unprecedented and had a clearly chilling effect on any progress that might have developed during the ongoing talks. Tokyo, Beijing, and Seoul each tried to lower the temperature, but mostly to no avail. The one positive result, at least from Beijing’s perspective, was that its influence began to displace the dominating influence that had been held by the United States since the end of WWII.

From 2003 thorough 2005 the Six-Party Talks foundered as the US positions seemed to continually shift. The Bush administration had hoped the configuration (five against one) would be enough to pressure the North into compromises, but that proved to be illusory. Japan and South Korea kept encouraging the Americans to enter bilateral talks with Pyongyang, which is what the North wanted, but that also proved a nonstarter.

As President Bush’s second term in office began, Pyongyang, expecting no change in the US positions of the past four years, decided to announce its departure from the Six-Party Talks. More importantly, it announced that its 1999 “unilateral missile moratorium” was no longer valid. In other words, it declared itself a nuclear-armed state, with the intent of creating a far ranging nuclear-ballistic missile capability, an offensive versus a defensive capability.

At this point South Korean President Roh Moo-hyun (노무현) stepped in. North-South talks had been moribund for years and Roh hoped that a new summit, only to be held after the finalization of a Six-Party agreement, along with an offer to provide 2000 Megawatts of electricity, might lure Pyongyang back to the Six-Party Talks. It was clear that the Light Water Reactor (LWR) project would never be built, and this offer would match the expected electrical output. Pyongyang, seeming to like playing the pliant South Koreans against the intransigent Americans, was non-committal. However, when the Chinese undiplomatically insisted that the North needed to return to the Six-Party Talks, it relented.

Over the summer of 2005, Pyongyang insisted that it had the right to possess civilian nuclear energy capabilities, as had been promised with the LWRs. This was completely opposed by hardline elements in Washington. The Chinese became determined to reach an agreement as talks continually bogged down on the issue of reactors. Finally, the Chinese told the Americans that if they did not bend towards acknowledging the North’s right to civilian nuclear energy there would be no deal.



Envoys gather for 2005 Six-Party Talks

The American delegation finally agreed to accept the Chinese formulation to be codified in a final Joint Statement but allow each of the five delegations to lay out conditions in their own final

statements. The North Korea had to rejoin the NPT as a member in good standing before any of the other nations could legally assist the North in establishing a civilian nuclear program.

In its own final statement, the United States asserted that the “appropriate time” for the discussion of LWRs would not come until the North had “eliminated all nuclear weapons and all nuclear programs, and this has been verified to the satisfaction of all parties by credible international means, including the IAEA; and when the DPRK has come into full compliance with the NPT and IAEA safeguards, and has demonstrated a sustained commitment to cooperation and transparency and has ceased proliferating nuclear technology.” Washington also added that “the United States supports a decision to terminate KEDO by the end of the year.” These words effectively communicated that, despite what was encompassed in the final Joint Statement, a civilian nuclear capability for North Korea was off the table.

In the eyes of DPRK leaders, the belligerent US statement regarding the Joint Statement cleared the path for them to fully develop and implement their nuclear and missile programs. Only a few months later, on 5 July 2006 (4 July in America) the KPA launched a Taepodong (대포동) ballistic missile along with five other tactical missiles. The Taepodong broke up shortly after liftoff, but the point had been made.



Taepodong-2 Missile (대포동-2)

The United States and Japan brought the issue to the UN Security Council pushing for tough sanctions, including the authorization of the use of force as outlined under Chapter Seven of the UN Charter, but China and Russia refused to support any such language. The final resolution (UNSCR 1695) simply called on member states to prevent “missile and missile-related items, materials, goods, and technology” from being transferred to or from the DPRK, and that the North “re-establish its pre-existing commitment to a moratorium on missile launching.”

Just three months after the July missile launches the DPRK conducted its first nuclear test. The effect of this was to spur Washington to engage North Korean diplomats, first in bilateral talks, then in follow-on Six-Party Talks in Beijing in December 2005 and January 2006. In those talks US and DPRK negotiators agreed on concrete steps for implementation of the tenets of the September 2005 Joint Statement. Given renewed American diplomatic activity, seemingly as a direct result of its nuclear test, may have convinced Pyongyang that possessing a credible nuclear capability provided it with political and diplomatic leverage. From that point into 2007, the Six-Party Talks took on new significance, as all parties seemed to be bargaining in good faith. By the summer of 2007, Pyongyang had again agreed to shut down its reactor at Yongbyon (냉변핵시설) and place it under IAEA monitoring, and the long-awaited North-South summit was finally in the works.

On 3 October, while President Roh was meeting with Kim in Pyongyang, a new Six-Party implementation process of the 2005 joint resolution, was reached, which called for the disablement and disassembly of the North’s nuclear program by year’s end, and the possibility that the North could be removed from the list of state sponsors of terrorism. However, any progress made began to founder quickly as agreements began to fall apart. The North’s import of aluminum tubes came into question. To assuage Washington’s fears, Pyongyang provided samples for US testing, which revealed traces of highly enriched uranium, and brought new accusations that the North had not stopped uranium enrichment. Additionally, the North Koreans themselves were slowing the work at Yongbyon. They also accused Japan of not providing its agreed portion of heavy fuel oil. Meanwhile,

the South Korean elections held that December ushered in the conservative government of Lee Myung-bak (이명박), who was hostile to Pyongyang, negating the positive results of the summit.

By 2008, it appeared that Kim Jong-il had already set in motion the process of succession for his third and youngest son, Kim Jong-un (김정은), to prepare him to be the North's next leader. The elder Kim's health had already begun to deteriorate when he had a severe stroke sometime around mid-August of 2008. While he did recover, his long-term prospects, given that he probably also suffered from diabetes, hypertension, and perhaps heart disease, were not good. Additionally, even after the stroke he continued to smoke and drink, which took an additional toll on his health. Still, in the three years he had left he remained extremely active, making over 300 public appearances, and taking four long trips – three to China and one to Russia.



Kim Jong-un
(김정은)

The Six-Party Talk process had one last ray of sunshine in late June, when Pyongyang delivered as agreed, but six months later, its declaration of past nuclear activities. Simultaneously, the United States lifted the provisions of the Trading with the Enemy Act, applied against the North, and started the 45-day notification clock required to remove the North from the State Sponsors of Terrorism list. However, by August Washington refused to remove the North from the terrorism list until a "strong verification regimen" was in place. A few days later the disablement work at Yongbyong stopped. The next month, the IAEA was told to remove its seals, cease surveillance, and its inspectors were banned from the nuclear complex. By the end of 2008, it was becoming clear that the Six-Party process was foundering in ways that would soon see its demise.

A month after President Obama's January 2009 inauguration, and notwithstanding his "we will extend a hand if you are willing to unclench your fist" entreaty, the North announced it would launch a satellite into orbit. In preparation, Pyongyang signed the international Outer Space Treaty, and gave requisite notice to mariners and aviators of the scheduled launch. The launch took place on 5 April and the UN Security Council condemned a week later. The day after the Security Council rebuke, Pyongyang announced it was withdrawing from the Six-Party Talks and restarting the nuclear facilities at Yongbyon. Pyongyang again banned the IAEA inspectors from the site and these steps drew sanctions from the Security Council (UNSCR 1874). Pyongyang responded by dramatically ratcheting up the stakes, stating that if the UN did not apologize:

"Firstly, the DPRK will be compelled to take additional self-defensive measures in order to defend its supreme interests. The measures will include nuclear tests and test-firings of intercontinental ballistic missiles. Secondly, the DPRK will make a decision to build a light water reactor power plant and start technological development for ensuring self-production of nuclear fuel as its first process without delay."

On 25 May, it conducted a second nuclear test, with an estimated yield of around six kilotons.

The Obama administration took these events as a personal affront, and Pyongyang's actions helped set in place an early US objective of changing North Korea's "behavior," and to break the cycle of "provocation and reward." Much later in the administration's first year its philosophy morphed into "strategic patience," as the White House refused to react to every provocation and began to distance itself from almost any form of engagement.

South Korean President Lee felt the previous two presidencies were a "lost decade" in North-South relations. However, as Pyongyang continued to look toward continued inter-Korea dialogue, Lee was not opposed to it.

In mid-November 2009, as the two governments were amid planning for a third summit, a naval incident scuttled any possible progress. In the West Sea, Republic of Korea Navy (ROKN) ships attacked a North Korean patrol boat that had crossed south of the Northern Limit Line, badly damaging it. Pyongyang was incensed that its ship was attacked rather given the usual warning. The ROKN claimed it made three warning announcements before firing a warning shot.



ROKS Cheonan (천안)

On the night of March 26, 2010, the South Korean naval corvette, ROKS Cheonan (천안), on routine patrol, was blown in half and sunk with all 46 on board. South Korea and the United States determined that a North Korean torpedo sank the vessel. The Chinese dismissed the scenario presented. Russia sent a team of experts to South Korea. No official statement on their assessment has been made, though it was claimed that they concluded a North Korean torpedo did not sink the ROKS Cheonan.

On 23 November 2010, North Korean artillery batteries began to shell South Korean artillery units as they ended an exercise on Yeonpyeong Island (연평도). Earlier, the KPA command passed a message to the ROKA directing they do not conduct the exercise, or they would receive a “resolute physical counterstrike,” to which the South ignored. The Southern units attempted to counter fire, but their efforts were ineffective. Two Marines and two civilians on the island died, while 19 were injured. The South declared it would schedule and execute another exercise, to which the North responded that doing so would result in “a second and third unpredictable self-defense blow.” The US counseled for restraint, and the South conducted a slightly altered exercise, which the North dismissed as “child’s play.”

North Korea under Kim Jong-un

Kim Jong-il convened a Workers Party conference, only the third in the history of the DPRK, for September 2011. It was part of the succession process where he would formally enshrine his son, Kim Jong-un, as his successor. The move seemed to be an effort to put the party back in place after Kim’s emphasis on “military first.” Over the past year, the younger Kim had accompanied his father on inspection trips, ensuring that he was seen and photographed. On his last trip to China, the elder Kim left his son in charge of the nation.

Kim Jong-il, the Dear Leader, died of a massive heart attack on the morning of 17 December 2011. On 30 December, the day after the memorial service, North Korean media announced that Kim Jong-un had “assumed the supreme commandship of the KPA at the bequest of leader Kim Jong-il” on October 8, 2011. Despite external doubts about the abilities of, and loyalty to, this young leader, he quickly asserted himself, spending the first day of the New Year conducting a methodical inspection of a premier tank unit, and receiving boisterous cheers from the soldiers and their officers.



Kim Jong-il funeral procession



Kim Jong-un with Kim Yong-nam (center) and Choe Yong-rim (center right)

Officially, Kim Jong-un is part of a triumvirate heading the executive branch of the North Korean government along with Premier Choe Yong-rim (최영림) and parliament chairman Kim Yong-nam (김영남). Each nominally holds powers equivalent to a third of a General Secretary's powers, as is the case in most other one-party communist states. Kim Jong-un commands the armed forces, Choe Yong-rim heads the government, and Kim Yong-nam handles foreign relations. Nevertheless, it is generally understood that Kim Jong-un, like his father and grandfather before him,

exercises absolute control over the government and the country. A constitutional amendment enacted by his father explicitly named the National Defense Commission chairman as "the Supreme Leader of the Democratic People's Republic of North Korea."

One of Kim's first orders of business was to repair relations with the United States. It was indicated during a conversation with the Russian deputy foreign minister. Kim's representative relayed that the North "was not opposed" to a discussion of a "moratorium on nuclear test and ballistic missile launches, access of IAEA experts to uranium enrichment facilities in the Yongbyon area, and a discussion of the issue of uranium enrichment." Talks convened in July 2011, with negotiations stretching into December, with the final "Leap Day" Agreement reached on 29 February 2012.

Instead of issuing a joint press release, there were parallel press releases, which were distinctly different. For the Americans, the most important part was the North's agreement to:

"Implement a moratorium on long-range missile launches, nuclear tests and nuclear activities at Yongbyon, including uranium enrichment activities. The DPRK also agreed to the return of IAEA inspectors to verify and monitor the moratorium on uranium enrichment activities at Yongbyon and confirm the disablement of the 5-MW reactor and associated facilities."

But from the DPRK perspective, the moratorium could only remain in effect "while productive dialogue continues," and limit IAEA activities to monitoring "the moratorium on uranium enrichment." While the North wanted to portray it as a joint agreement, the US statement downplayed that aspect, stating that the "United States still has profound concerns regarding North Korean behavior across a wide range of areas."

This agreement fell apart quickly when Pyongyang announced plans for an April launch of a "working satellite" from its west coast launch facility. UN Security Council resolutions had forbidden this activity on several occasions. US representatives stated they had argued that a space program would be a deal breaker, while the North supposedly countered that the moratorium construct would preclude the North's "right" to a space program. The launch took place as scheduled on 13 April 2012, with the rocket veering off course and exploding a minute into its flight.



North Korea's satellite launch

Eight months later, they conducted a second launch and this one successfully placed a satellite into orbit. The North's scientists and technicians were becoming increasingly competent, and their ability to build an effective nuclear weapons program, combined with a ballistic missile with which to deliver them would soon come to fruition. Over the next 5 years, Kim's nuclear and missile programs, as well as a menacing cyber capability, would demonstrate the capabilities that he was building, and how he might intend to employ them.

Between 2006 and 2017, the DPRK has conducted six successful nuclear tests. In parallel, its ballistic missile program conducted over 30 launches with the Hwasong-15 (화성15호) missile achieving a potential 13,000-kilometer range.

Following a 28 July 2017 ICBM test by the North, the UN Security Council unanimously passes UNSCR 2371 (2017) restricting crude oil imports. On 8 August, in response to North Korea's criticism of the resolution, President Trump tells reporters that "North Korea best not make any more threats to the United States" and that "They will be met with fire and fury like the world has never seen." The DPRK conducts its latest nuclear test on 3 September. This test had an estimated yield between 70-280 kilotons of explosive power. Eight days later the Security Council passes UNSCR 2375 (2017). Later in November the North launched an ICBM which traveled 1,000 kilometers and landed in the Sea of Japan. In response the UN Security Council passes UNSCR 2397 (2017) on 22 December, further restricting crude oil imports. North Korea calls the resolution an act of war.

Additionally, it is known that the North has an active chemical weapons program, although it claims that it does not. South Korean intelligence agencies estimate that the North possesses 2500 to 5000 metric tons of chemical agents, to include VX nerve agents.

Of increasing concern, the DPRK has developed a robust cyber weaponry capability. They began to attract serious notice in 2014 with an attack on the Sony Pictures Corporation. Sony released the film "The Interview" that mocked the Kim regime. The North also hacked over 30,000 South Korean computers in three television stations, a bank, and the website of then-President Park Geun-hye. The most recent attack attributed to the North's Bureau 121, their cyber warfare agency, came in May 2017. The "WannaCry" ransomware attack affected over 230,000 computers, in over 150 countries. The British National Health Service in England and Scotland were especially hard hit, with over 70,000 devices affected, including computers, MRI scanners, and blood storage refrigerators.



WannaCry screen shot

In 2012 the Japan-North Korea Intergovernmental Consultations began again. These meetings continued off and on for the following two years with the issue of Japanese nationals' abductions being a primary sticking point. In May 2014, in Stockholm, the North promised comprehensive full-scale investigation into all Japanese abductees. Japan decided to lift part of its own measures against the DPRK once they establish the Special Investigation Committee.

From 2012 through 2017 Kim continued to consolidate control over all aspects of DPRK governance. His uncle, and mentor, Jang Song-thaek (장성택), was executed for treachery in 2013. O Sang-hon (오상훈), Deputy Security Minister, in the Ministry of Public Security, was killed in a 2014 political purge. And in 2015, Hyon Yong-chol (현영철), the Minister of People's Armed Forces, and Choe Yong-gon (최영건), the Deputy Minister of Construction and Building Material Industries were both

executed. On 13 February 2017, Kim's half-brother, Kim Jong-nam (김정남), was assassinated in the middle of Kuala Lumpur International Airport, Malaysia. He died from the effects of a VX nerve agent.

South Korean politics and the Olympics

In early 2013 South Koreans went to the polls and elected Park Geun-hye (박근혜) as the country's first female president. Park was the daughter of former president Park Chung-hee. Her policies, regarding North Korea, focused on trust-building and eventual reunification as outlined in her Korean Peninsula Trust-building Process: a three-step initiative 1) securing peace, 2) economic integration, 3) political integration.

However, she was staunch in her determination to penalize the North for its continued missile and nuclear tests and sought to harmonize Seoul's positions with those of the China, Russia, the United States, and the United Nations. Her government's support for the passage of UNSCR 2094 (2013) was seen as the catalyst for Pyongyang to cease threats toward the South and suggest talks on reopening the Kaesong Industrial Complex.

In 2016 President Park became embroiled in a corruption scandal and was removed from office on 10 March 2017. She was impeached on charges of corruption and cronyism and subsequently imprisoned. On 10 May 2017, in a special election, Moon Jae-in (문재인), a former human rights lawyer and candidate of the liberal Democratic United Party, was sworn in as the President of South Korea.



Moon Jae-in (문재인)

As Moon came into office, plans for the return of the Olympics, this time the 2018 winter games in Pyeongchang (평창군), South Korea were well underway. President Moon quickly seized upon the upcoming games to reduce tensions and restart a dialog with the North. In late December 2017, the South sent a representative to the one inter-Korea exchange still going on – a youth soccer game in China – to send the message that DPRK athletes would be welcome at the winter games. Shortly thereafter President Moon stated that he favored postponing the annual joint ROK-US military exercises.

Moon kept offering overtures to the North for its participation, but missile and nuclear tests, countered by UN sanctions, kept getting in the way. As the Olympics drew closer, the North's attitude finally seemed to change. Once the United States agreed to postpone the annual exercises, the path was finally clear for the North to agree to attend. On 31 December, in a televised address, Kim Jong-un offered to send a delegation to the Winter Olympics. In what seemed to the world to be an overnight turnaround, to gain North Korea's participation in the games, it was, in fact, a triumph of months of quiet negotiation.

Mixed optimism

In the same New Year's Eve address in which Kim offered to send a delegation to the winter games, he also chided the United States, stating: "It's not a mere threat, but a reality that I have a nuclear button on the desk in my office. All the mainland of the United States is within the range of our nuclear strike." In the month before that, the White House reinstated North Korea to the list of state sponsors of terrorism. This was 9 years after having been removed from the list by the Bush administration amid the Six Party Talks.

However, as 2018 began, given the real possibility that the DPRK would participate in the Winter Olympic Games, the overall tone quickly shifted to a sense of real optimism. On 9 January North and South Korean diplomats meet at Panmunjom and agreed that North Korea would send a large delegation to the Winter Olympics. They also agreed to reopen the government and military hotlines, that had been shut down for the past two years.

In February, as the world's attention shifted to the Winter Olympics, Kim Jong-un's younger sister, Kim Yo-jong (김여정), communicates an invitation to South Korean President Moon Jae-in for summit meeting in Pyongyang. Kim Yo-jong was reportedly scheduled to meet with the US Vice President Pence but the meeting was cancelled due to new US sanctions. In early March, South Korean envoys prepping for the expected ROK-DPRK summit meeting return from meetings in Pyongyang reporting that Kim Jong-un is willing to begin direct negotiations with the United States on abandoning its nuclear weapons program.



Kim Yo-jong (upper right) with Moon Jae-in (lower left) at Olympic opening ceremony

On 10 March, President Trump accepts Kim Jong-un's offer to direct negotiations. A few weeks later, in apparent preparation for Trump-Kim summit meeting, Kim Jong-un conducts his first ever state visit, to see Xi Jinping (习近平) in Beijing. This marks his first sojourn outside of North Korea since the death of his father. Chinese press reports stated that Kim reemphasized his willingness to open a dialogue with the United States and is committed to the denuclearization of the Korean Peninsula.

On 1 April US and ROK forces resume their planned annual exercises; however, this time without the normal protests and posturing from the DPRK. On the same day CIA Director, and Secretary of State designate, Mike Pompeo, secretly traveled to Pyongyang to meet with Supreme Leader Kim. During a state visit by Japanese Prime Minister Shinzo Abe (安倍 晋三), President Trump revealed he had given his endorsement to President Moon to put on the agenda of the upcoming Inter-Korean summit a possible peace treaty to end the Korean War.

In the run-up to the ROK-DPRK summit scheduled for later in the month, Kim stated that he would no longer demand the removal of US troops from South Korea, as a precondition for denuclearization. He also announced he would retire his regime's *Byungjin* (병진) policy where they simultaneously develop nuclear weapons and the economy. Having achieved a 'great victory' there was no longer a need to test long-range missiles and nuclear weapons, and therefore he would shut down Punggye-ri (풍계리 핵 실험장) nuclear test site. Kim stated he would instead adopt a new strategic line focused on rebuilding his nation's economy.



Kim & Moon Peace House Summit

On 27 April, in the first ever visit of a North Korean leader to South Korea, Kim Jong-un and Moon Jae-in meet for a summit at the Peace House in the DMZ. The achievements of the meeting were codified in the "Panmunjom Declaration for Peace, Prosperity and Reunification of the Korean Peninsula." As expressed in the statement, their "common goal" is of an official end of the Korean War and the denuclearization of the Korean peninsula. On 1 May, South Korea ended propaganda broadcasts across the DMZ and began dismantling the loudspeaker system that had been in

operation for decades. Shortly thereafter, Kim Jong-un ended “Pyongyang Time” setting his country’s clocks to match the South Korean time zone.

During the summit Kim Jong-un told Moon Jae-in that he would abandon his nuclear weapons if the US agreed to formally end the Korean War and promise to not invade his country. Kim was also reported as stating that he would invite security experts and journalists to observe the closure of the Punggye-ri nuclear site and was ready to meet with Japanese Prime Minister Abe.

3 May 2018, for the first time in 11 years a Chinese Foreign Minister, Wang Yi (王毅), visited Pyongyang. Yi met with Kim, probably to ensure that Beijing did not lose influence or become sidelined as Kim courted both Seoul and Washington. Five days later, Kim met with Xi for the second time in two months. Chinese state media reports that Kim says that “North Korea hopes relevant parties can adopt step-by-step and synchronized measures to advance the process of political settlement and eventually achieve denuclearization and lasting peace on the Korean Peninsula.”

Simultaneously, President Trump ordered the Pentagon to prepare options for drawing down US military units stationed in South Korea. This came at a sensitive time, as it was also during the renegotiation of the cost-sharing agreement on the stationing of US forces in South Korea, which expired at the end of 2018. Unless South Korea agreed to pay the entire cost – approximately \$1.6 billion – for its own defense, the Trump administration suggested it may move some, if not all, US forces off the Korean peninsula.

As the summit neared, the DPRK threatened to cancel if the White House insisted on forcing the DPRK into “unilateral nuclear abandonment.” In late May, the North publicly destroyed tunnels at the Punggye-ri nuclear test site. That same day, President Trump, in a letter to Chairman Kim, cancelled the summit “based on tremendous anger and open hostility,” but also wrote that, “if you change your mind having to do with this most important summit, please do not hesitate to call or write me.” Then, in the wake of the surprise summit between Kim and Moon in which the North stated it was willing to talk about “complete denuclearization” and after receiving a “very nice statement” from Kim, Trump changed his mind. By 1 June, the summit was back on. In the run-up to the talks, the Pentagon cancelled joint US-ROK exercises scheduled for August.

The summit was held on 12 June in Singapore. The agenda commenced with a one-on-one meeting between Trump and Kim, with their interpreters being the only others present. This was followed by an expanded bilateral meeting, then a working lunch. This ended the formal meetings, and the parties left Singapore that evening. Both leaders issued a brief joint statement:

President Trump and Chairman Kim Jong-un state the following:

- 1. The United States and the DPRK commit to establish new US-DPRK relations in accordance with the desire of the peoples of the two countries for peace and prosperity.*
- 2. The United States and the DPRK will join their efforts to build a lasting and stable peace regime on the Korean Peninsula.*
- 3. Reaffirming the April 27, 2018, Panmunjom Declaration, the DPRK commits to work towards the complete denuclearization of the Korean Peninsula.*
- 4. The United States and the DPRK commit to recovering POW/MIA remains including the immediate repatriation of those already identified.*



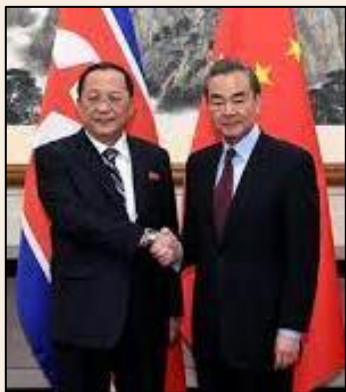
Kim & Trump in
Singapore

While small steps, such as the first returns of US military remains, resumption of family reunions, beginning a joint effort to clear landmines in the DMZ, and the continued rapport between Kim and

the Moon were taken, relations between Pyongyang and Washington grew increasingly tense. Washington continued to focus on denuclearization, Pyongyang continued to point to those things it had already done and pushed for sanctions relief. President Moon continued to see his role as a mediator between both sides and met again with Kim in Pyongyang in mid-September.

Apparently, Kim took the order of the four statements in the Singapore Summit's Joint Statement as the actual order under which issues would be resolved, with denuclearization being third in that order, behind 'new relations' and a 'peace regime' on the Korean peninsula. In late September, South Korea began to push for the resolution of the Korean War as a first step that would address the first two points and began to push for increased economic links between the North and South through new roads and railroads. Trump however warned that Seoul could "do nothing" without Washington's "approval." Washington accused both China and Russia of undermining, and actively subverting, the sanctions on North Korea.

US Secretary of State Pompeo had a planned visit to Pyongyang in August, as a follow up to the summit, but his trip was cancelled by President Trump. This was due to the poor state of relations since the summit. When Pompeo finally did return, in early October, he extracted a commitment from North Korea to allow inspectors into the North's nuclear testing site. By the end of the month a South Korean team was allowed access. Kim also agreed to a second summit as soon as possible but no date was set.



Ri Yong Ho and Wang Yi

6 December 2018, North Korean Foreign Minister Ri Yong Ho (리용호) meets with Chinese Foreign Minister Wang to discuss relations and a possible summit between President Xi and Kim. In early January 2019, Kim travels to Beijing for his fourth meeting with Xi. The denuclearization process was discussed along with an invitation for Xi to visit North Korea.

Later in January top DPRK diplomat, Kim Yong-chol (김영철) meets with Trump for over 90-minutes. After the meeting, the White House announces a second summit between President Trump and Chairman Kim will take place at the end of February. A day later the North's Vice Foreign Minister, US Special Representative Stephen Biegun, and a South Korean negotiator meet near Stockholm, Sweden to discuss

"confidence building, economic development and long-term engagement."

27-28 February, Kim and Trump meet in Hanoi, Vietnam for their second summit. The North called for sanctions to be lifted "in their entirety" in exchange for partial denuclearization but the US rejected this. Ri later stated that the North had requested partial removal of sanctions in exchange for a permanent halt of nuclear and ballistic missile testing. Though no agreements were signed the Pyongyang Times, state newspaper of the DPRK, welcomed the "constructive and candid exchange of opinions."

In April President Moon meets with Trump in Washington and states he would prefer a "big deal" with the North to "get rid of the nuclear weapons." Trump states that he would support joint economic projects between the two Koreas, but sanctions would "remain in place" until denuclearization is complete. A day after Moon's visit Kim, speaking at the Supreme People's Assembly, that he would attend a third US-DPRK summit. He states that the US must "lay down unilateral requirements and seek constructive solutions."

Later in April Kim met with Russian President Vladimir Putin in Vladivostok, Russia, for the first time. Kim asked Putin to help resolve the stalemate with the US. Putin stated, "Chairman Kim Jong-un himself asked us to inform the American side about his position." He later stated that "there are no secrets here. We will discuss this with the Americans and our Chinese partners."

Chinese President Xi traveled to Pyongyang, for the first time as President, in June. Xi emphasized the importance of strengthening cooperation between their countries. He also praised the North's actions to promote denuclearization. This was the fifth meeting between Xi and Kim. Immediately following Xi's visit DPRK media reports that Kim received a letter from Trump that contains "excellent content." The letter was dated a week prior to Xi's visit.



Kim Jong-un and Vladimir Putin

26 June, President Moon Jae-in says that if the North dismantles the Yongbyon nuclear complex facility, including the plutonium reprocessing facilities and the uranium enrichment facilities, it will signal "that denuclearization of North Korea has entered an irreversible state." He continued that this could "help the international community seek a partial or gradual easing of the U.N. Security Council sanctions." Two days later Trump tweeted "I will be leaving Japan for South Korea (with President Moon). While there, if Chairman Kim of North Korea sees this, I would meet him at the Border/DMZ just to shake his hand and say Hello(?)"



Trump and Kim at the DMZ

President Trump meets with Chairman Kim at the DMZ on 30 June. Both agree to resume negotiations and that working-level talks will begin within several weeks. The Korean Central News Agency (KCNA) carried extensive coverage of the meeting. Considering how the KCNA had depicted the US as its most hated enemy it was quite a contrast for North Koreans to see Trump walking into the North as a friend of Supreme Leader Kim. Critics dismissed the occasion as an act of political theater and that it did nothing to make progress towards the DPRK giving up its nuclear program.

US-ROK joint military exercise Dong Maeng (동맹) began on 5 August. The following day the North condemns the exercise stating, "constructive dialogue cannot be expected at a time when a simulated war practice targeted at the dialog partner is being conducted." On the same day, the North tested two short-range ballistic missiles. This was the second of five tests that took place between July and August 2019. On 27 August, France, Germany, and the United Kingdom issue a UN Security Council statement condemning the ballistic missile launches as provocations.

During the South Korean Independence Day's 74th Anniversary celebration, President Moon vowed reunification of the Korean peninsula by 2045. Pyongyang viewed this statement as provocative and immediately rejected further peace talks with Seoul. An unidentified spokesman stated that the decision to break off talks was "completely the fault of South Korea's actions."

At the end of September North Korea's new chief negotiator, Kim Myong-gil (김명길), released a statement stating that he "welcome[s] President Trump's wise political decision to approach the DPRK-US relations from a more practical point of view." The DPRK Ambassador to the UN delivered a speech at the General Assembly where he proposed a return to working-level talks with the US. The talks convene in Stockholm, Sweden on 4-5 October but quickly fall apart when both sides fail to

reach a consensus. The US State Department quickly issues a statement on reconvening talks in two weeks, but Kim Myong-gil accuses the US of having an “outdated stance and attitude” and turns down the invitation.

During mid-November North Korea’s State Affairs Commission released a statement condemning a proposed joint US-ROK military exercise. US Secretary of Defense, Mark Esper, mentions the possibility of adjusting the upcoming event to promote diplomacy. Kim Yong-chol lauds the announcement but warns that if the exercise is not cancelled the North “will be compelled to answer with shocking punishment that would be difficult for the US to cope with.” Secretary Esper announces on 17 November that the exercise will be postponed. Kim Yong-chol responds saying, “the suspension of the drill does not mean ensuing peace and security on the Korean peninsula and is not helpful to the diplomatic efforts for the settlement of issues.”

With pressure on an end-of-year deadline for negotiations both sides continue to posture. On 3 December the DPRK Vice Foreign Minister for US Affairs stated, “The DPRK has done everything transparently and openly so far. It feels no need to hide what it will do from now on and therefore, reminds the US once again that the year-end limit comes nearer” and “what is left to be done now is the US option and it is entirely up to the US what Christmas gift it will select to get.” At a NATO meeting in London, Trump avows, “we are more powerful, militarily, than we have ever been...hopefully, we don’t have to use it, but if we do, we’ll use it.” He goes on further to state “I hope [Kim Jong-un] lives up to the agreement, but we’re going to find out.” 2019 closes out with no further movement in the dialog.

2020 rang in with Kim chairing the plenary meeting of the Central Committee of the Worker’s Party of Korea. At the meeting Kim announced that the DPRK would no longer be “unilaterally bound” to any former concessions made. He added that North Korea would be “chilling [its] efforts for worldwide nuclear disarmament and non-proliferation.” and that he would pursue a “new strategic weapon.”

2020’s to present day

As first quarter of 2020 concluded, the North resumed its ballistic missile testing. Four tests of the Hwasong-11 (황성11호) and KN-25 missiles were conducted in March alone with Kim overseeing them. The KCNA stated that the firings were to demonstrate to KPA officers the “tactical characters and power of a new weapon system to be delivered.”



Kim Yo-jong (김여정)

Despite Kim’s tone, South Korea continued to push resumption of US-DPRK negotiations. President Trump sent a letter to Kim where he “wished the family of the chairman and our people wellbeing.” Kim Yo-jong responded to the letter stating “the personal letter between the two leaders” is not sufficient to re-start dialogue. Secretary Pompeo asked G7 leaders to “stay committed to applying diplomatic and economic pressure over [North Korea’s] illegal nuclear and ballistic missile programs.” Pyongyang issued a rebuttal to Pompeo saying, “We will go our own way. We do not want the US to bother us. If the US bothers us, it will be hurt.”

In April, rumors of Kim Jong-un’s ill health created internet speculation and consternation. He was absent from the 11 April Politburo meeting and the annual observance of Kim Il-sung on 15 April. The celebration for his grandfather, called the “Day of the Sun,” is the most important event in North Korea. Theories that he was recovering from heart surgery to contracting the coronavirus were rampant. Rumors that Kim

Yo-jong would be the possible successor if Kim Jong-un had died. Then in early May photos resurfaced that he was still alive.

In May, Russian Ambassador to North Korea, Alexander Matsegora, suggests that the DPRK will postpone dialog with the US until after the US Presidential Election. Matsegora stated that North Korea has deemed negotiations with the US as "pointless for now."

In June, following the DPRK Political Bureau of the Central Committee of the Worker's Party of Korea meeting Pyongyang announces plans to cut all communication lines with Seoul. This was in response to "anti-DPRK leaflets" being dropped along the border between the North and South. The North blamed authorities in the South for conniving the act. KCNA stated, "this has driven the inter-Korean relations into catastrophe." DPRK Foreign Ministry warns the US against interfering in worsening relations. On 17 June, the North demolishes the inter-Korean liaison office in Kaesong, North Korea.

Throughout the summer of 2020 rhetoric continued back and forth between the South, North, and US. Then in October the KPA unveiled the world's largest road-mobile, liquid-fueled, ICBM during a parade celebrating the 75th anniversary of the Worker's Party. The Hwasong-16 (화성16호) has an estimated range of 13,000 km and estimated payload of 2,000-3,500 kg.



Hwasong-16 (화성16호)

During the final US Presidential debate, on 22 October, President Trump says he has "a very good relationship" with Kim and "there's no war." Former Vice President Joseph Biden likens Kim to Nazi Germany's Adolf Hitler and calls him a "thug" but says he would meet with him if denuclearization were agreed.

North Korea was oddly silent on the victory of Joe Biden, in November. Typically, they acknowledge election outcomes soon after results are announced. Analysts feel that Kim does not want to incite the incoming US President. President-elect Biden had indicated that it may not resume "strategic patience" that his predecessors had used. South Korea pushed the incoming administration to revive talks and use the 2021 Tokyo Olympics as an occasion like the 2018 Olympics. The North ended up not send a delegation to the Tokyo Olympics.

The first time that Kim publicly commented on President Biden he mentioned that his country needs to prepare for both "dialog and confrontation" with the US. His comments came in June where he also followed with "especially to get fully prepared for confrontation in order to protect the dignity of our state."

July 2021, President Xi Jinping and Chairman Kim Jong-un renewed the China-North Korea Treaty of Friendship, Co-operation, and Mutual Assistance for 20 additional years. This agreement was initially signed 11 July 1961. The treaty is the only defense treaty that both nations have.



Xi Jinping & Kim Jung-un

27 August 2021, the IAEA says that the North has restarted operations at a power plant capable of producing plutonium for nuclear weapons. This was based on observations made in early July, which they had not seen since December 2018.

In September, Kim ordered officials to restore communications lines with South Korea to "promote peace." Despite his desire to re-open communications with the South he warned that "mutual respect must be guaranteed, and unfair views and double standards attitude

dropped.” This was seen as a step forward with the Seoul even as Kim condemned US policy as being “hostile.”

Japan’s new Prime Minister Fumio Kishida (岸田 文雄) came into office in October. Kishida’s first official talk was with President Biden. They confirmed that they will strengthen the Japan-United States alliance and cooperate in regional security. In Fumio’s first major speech, on 8 October, he critically called out North Korea and stated that their nuclear developments are “absolutely unacceptable.” He then followed up pledging to meet with Kim Jong-un to resolve the abduction of Japanese citizens.

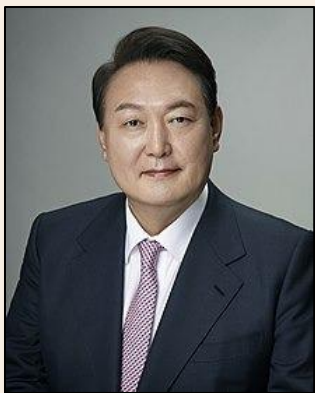


Fumio Kishida (岸田 文雄)

Kim addressed the Central Committee of the Worker’s Party politburo on 1 December notifying his country to prepare for a “very giant struggle” in 2022. He urged that they must continue to make progress in defense, agriculture, and construction. With the North facing food shortages, and continued economic stagnation, the Worker’s Party has been pushing a five-year economic plan unveiled in early 2021. Even with current progress, the country is plagued by power shortages and food scarcity due to the sanctions imposed by the United Nations.

In early January 2022, Pyongyang claimed to fire hypersonic weapons and cruise missiles. The US imposed sanctions on individuals linked to weapons programs. A test hiatus during February occurred as the Olympic games were held in Beijing. On the 11th North Korean newspaper Rodong Sinmun wrote a glowing editorial about Chinese President Xi and Chairman Kim. In the article the term “Suryong (수령),” or “supreme leader,” was used to describe Kim Jong-un. This term historically has only been used for Kim Il Sung.

President Moon and Chairman Kim met for a summit in March. Both leaders agreed that they will sign a peace treaty soon. Moon stated that “a new era of peace has begun and there will be no more war on the Korean Peninsula.” Kim expressed his desires for the two Koreas to “come together as one united people and work towards reunification.”



Yoon Suk-yeol (윤석열)

May 2022, South Korea swore in a new President Yoon Suk-yeol (윤석열). Yoon was the former Prosecutor General prior to running for the Presidency. President Yoon expressed his intentions to reconsider, or possibly scrap, the September 2018 Panmunjom Declaration between the DPRK and ROK. Critics feel that the agreement has been instrumental in preventing military confrontation between the two Koreas.

The US-led “Rim of the Pacific Exercise” began on 29 June off the coast of Hawaii. South Korean armed forces and Japanese Self Defense Forces participated in this biennial exercise along with 23 other nations. The DPRK criticized the exercise as “fostering US military supremacy over Asia-Pacific.” In July multiple rocket launches were reported emanating from North Korea thought to be in retaliation. President Yoon immediately ordered the ROK military to retaliate against any provocation from the North “promptly and sternly.”

The DPRK launched an intermediate range ballistic missile over Japan in early October. This was the first IRBM overflight of Japan since 2017. This latest test was the part of 15 missile tests in a three-week period. Later in the month North and South Korean vessels traded shots near the maritime border Northern Limit Line over a merchant vessel crossing the line. The DPRK denied involvement in the incident.

November 2022 marked the continued missile testing by Pyongyang with their largest intercontinental ballistic missile the Hwasong-17 being fired. This marks the first successful launch of the Hwasong-17 and raised concerns this missile being capable of eventually housing a nuclear warhead. In December the DPRK launched a “carrier rocket” for its space program. State media noted that the country was now making “preparations for military reconnaissance satellite No. 1 by April 2023.”

January 11, 2023, ROK President Yoon sparked controversy after commenting that South Korea could consider building nuclear weapons if the nuclear threat from North Korea grows. The remarks were off-the-cuff and Government officials subsequently noted it was not official policy. This grew speculation about whether South Korea may one day pursue nuclear weapons.

On March 28th North Korea released images of purported tactical nuclear warhead casings. The images, if real, project that the DPRK can miniaturize and produce such a weapon to fit onto its growing ballistic missile arsenal.

In first state visit to the US, President Yoon met with President Biden on April 26th. The US-ROK alliance was enhanced by the Washington Declaration. Yoon reaffirmed his country’s commitment to nuclear non-proliferation following his comments earlier in the year.

Pyongyang attempted its first satellite launch on May 31st with the rocket crashing off their west coast. They vowed a second attempt. This comes on the tail end of US-ROK live-fire exercise commemorating the 70th anniversary of their alliance. The DPRK sent two short-range ballistic missiles into Japan’s EEZ in response.



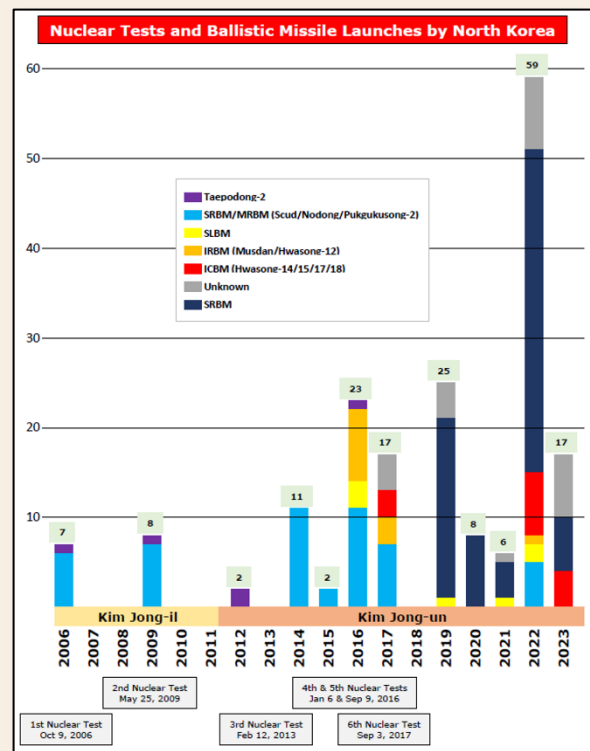
Shoigu-Kim visit

Russian Defence Minister Sergei Shoigu visited Pyongyang to mark the 70th anniversary of the Korean War Armistice Agreement in July. Shoigu proposed trilateral naval exercises between Russia, China, and North Korea. The DPRK have yet to agree to such joint drills.

Kim Jong-un visited Russia in early September to meet with Vladimir Putin. This meeting fueled suspicion that a weapons deal was in the works. President Putin was asked if Russia would help North Korea build satellites he stated, “that’s why [they] came

here.” Speculation on munitions supplies from North Korea to Russia, to support war efforts in Ukraine, were confirmed by the US in mid-October. The evidence pointed to shipping containers that traveled from Rajin, North Korea, to the Russian military port of Dunay.

Chinese President Xi and Russian President Putin decided to skip the G20 New Delhi summit in September. Speculations to why Xi skipped focused on the ongoing border dispute with India. Putin chose not to attend due to Ukraine being on the topic list as well as the planned visit by Kim Jong-un.



Nuclear Tests and Ballistic Missile Launches

On September 26th North Korean UN Ambassador, Kim Song, accused the US of making 2023 an “extremely dangerous year” and denouncing both US and South Korean leaders for “hysterical remarks of confrontation.” He later stated that “the United States is now moving on to the practical stage of realizing its sinister intention to provoke a nuclear war” and that they were introducing a “new Cold War structure to northeast Asia.”

In Late October the US, Japan, and South Korea conducted their first ever trilateral aerial exercise. This follows an agreement by the three countries to “deepen defense cooperation” that was discussed in a historic August 2023 summit. One aspect of the exercise was simulating an artillery attack on Seoul from the North.

The third time is a charm as North Korea successfully placed a satellite into orbit on November 21st. This reconnaissance satellite launch did not appear to have a determinative help from Russia. The first stage was detonated after separation to prevent retrieval from sea. South Korea responded to the launch by suspending a part of the 2018 military agreement with Pyongyang. Thus, restoring full aerial reconnaissance and surveillance along the DMZ.



Kim Jung-un observing satellite launch

In the first part of 2024 North Korea conducts multiple cruise-missile test firings. In early February Kim Jong Un calls for strengthening his country’s naval force to defend its maritime sovereignty. The fifth firing came while the U.S. and Japan conducted an air and missile defense exercise. Japan plans on training and firing Tomahawk cruise missiles in late March.

On March 25 North Korea claimed that Japanese Prime Minister Kishida requested a summit. The DPRK said that any meeting was unlikely without a policy shift by Tokyo. It was reported that Kishida asked to use “another channel” to convey his position to Kim.

Beginning at the end of May the DPRK has launched approximately 1,600 trash-carrying balloons towards the ROK. This was in response to anti-Pyongyang leaflets being sent northwards. In retaliation the ROK resumed loudspeaker broadcasts across the DMZ which in turn caused the DPRK to reinstall its own loudspeakers along the border. Several dozen North Korean soldiers mistakenly crossed the DMZ on June 11. They turned back after South Korean troops fired warning shots.

In October, the DPRK amended their constitution defining South Korea as a hostile state. In addition, they demolished rail and roads connecting the two countries and increased fortifications along their mutual border (which continued throughout the remainder of 2024 and into 2025).

October saw Shigeru Ishiba elected as Japan’s Prime Minister. His election came after Kishida announced he would not seek re-election. Ishiba named regional security as his primary concern stating that its “most sever since the end of World War II.”

November saw signs of increasing closeness between the DPRK and Russia. In this month, the DPRK sent thousands of troops to the Kursk region of Russia to defend against Ukrainian offensive as a part of their mutual defense treaty. This is an increase in support from the artillery and rocket ammunition that the DPRK had provided and possibly was a key component of Russia’s ability to regain much of the territory it lost to Ukrainian forces.

With the re-election of Donald Trump as U.S. President, in November, North Korean press was surprisingly silent. The first mention by DPRK state media came on January 22, 2025.

There was political uncertainty in South Korea in late 2024 and early 2025. In December, South Korean President Yoon Suk-yeol briefly declared martial law and sent troops to occupy parliament citing the need to protect the country from “North Korean communist forces” and “anti-state forces.” However, the institution of martial law was not successful and President Yoon Suk-yeol was impeached and removed from office after South Korea’s Constitutional Court in April of 2025 upheld his impeachment.

In early June 2025, South Korea held an election and elected Lee Jae-myung, the leader of South Korea's Democratic Party of Korea (DPK), who ran on seeking to improve relations with China and ease tensions with the DPRK. South Korea subsequently stopped loudspeaker broadcasts at the North Korean border and President Lee Jae-myung made positive overtures to the DPRK, to which Kim Yo-jong stated that he was no different than his predecessors. Undeterred, in August President Lee marked the 80th anniversary of the end of World War II by calling for gradual steps to restore the Comprehensive Military Agreement with the DPRK.



Lee Jae-myung (이재명)

Over the first half of 2025, North Korea continued building upon its relationship with Russia and appearing to improve its diplomatic position. In June, the DPRK reportedly pledged to send thousands of troops to Kursk to support mine-sweeping and reconstruction. Then, on September 3, China held a military parade commemorating the 80th anniversary of the end of World War II, which saw the leaders of China, Russia, and North Korea together at a public event for the first time since the 1950s.

An article was printed on September 5 revealing details of a U.S. Navy SEAL team mission to infiltrate North Korea and implant a listening device back in 2019. The mission failed to complete its task and ended up killing civilian fishermen prior to aborting, so the article states. North Korean state media has not formally commented on the incident.

In September Japan held snap elections and Sanae Takaichi (高市 早苗) was elected as Prime Minister. In early November she expressed willingness to hold talks with North Korean Leader Kim Jong Un to discuss the issue of abducted Japanese nationals. She added that Japan will take every step it can to achieve a breakthrough that produces concrete results.

Tensions between the two Koreas remains steady with growing concern that dialog is not possible without support from other parties.



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